

2005: Becomes CM heading a JD(U)-BJP alliance, starts a long period of political dominance in Bihar

2013: Breaks with the BJP over Narendra Modi being projected as the NDA's PM candidate

2014: Steps down as CM, instals Jitan Ram Manjhi in his place after JD(U)'s poor show in the LS polls

at the Centre will be crucial here. Historically, the party's base has been heavily anchored in Nitish's caste men, the Kurmi and Kushwaha, in addition to key segments of the EBCs, who collectively make up around 36 per cent of Bihar's population. The JD(U) will aim to consolidate these groups while also maintaining goodwill with small backward castes such as Telis, Mallahs and Nonias. The immediate task is to maintain its foothold among the non-Yadav OBCs, even as the BJP continues to make further inroads. This will again be critical for the JD(U) to remain a negotiating partner and stem the complete erosion of its vote bank.

The strategic significance was clear, for even Union home minister Shah had flown down to Patna for the filing of RS nominations. Alongside Nitish, Union minister Ram Nath Thakur, BJP national president Nitin Nabin and the party's Dalit heavyweight Shivesh Ram too filed on March 5.



WITHOUT NITISH'S PERSONAL CONNECT, THE JD(U) RISKS RAPID DISINTEGRATION. PERHAPS WHY SOME IN THE PARTY WANT HIS SON, NISHANT KUMAR, TO TAKE ON THE MANTLE, BELIEVING THE SUPPORT BASE WOULD GRAVITATE TOWARDS HIM

public persona has periodically sparked speculation about a political role, remains a politically untested entity.

Within the JD(U), there are already two distinct camps, one set of legislators open to joining the BJP and embracing a new political order, the other seeking to preserve the party's independent socialist identity. For the JD(U), this evolution will cast real pressure on its survival, particularly in the mid-term. The party's options are limited as, unlike in the past when Nitish did his flip-flops, the math this time is not that benign. The Opposition bloc has only 35 MLAs, which makes any alternative alignment both numerically fragile and politically implausible.

To navigate this new landscape, the JD(U) will focus on retaining its strategic caste balancing. Ministerial berths and other appointments in the state as well as in the possible cabinet reshuffle

THE SAFFRON SURGE

Having addressed the Nitish situation successfully, another major decision awaits: the party is yet to announce its pick for chief minister. The BJP central leadership, especially in the Modi-Shah era, has a reputation for delivering surprises, perhaps why many of the well-known names are playing it cool. The new regime will have a little less than a full five-year tenure to cement the BJP's governance model.

It will not be easy going at first, especially with the image—prevalent among even JD(U) supporters—that Nitish had been "tricked" into giving up the CM's post. The Opposition, especially, has been talking this up. RJD chief Tejashwi Yadav sent a caustic comment, "Nitish Kumar imposed the BJP's communal and caste-based politics on Bihar. He has today received his punishment, in the form of complete surrender before the BJP."

The BJP think-tanks are acutely aware of Nitish's personal appeal among the EBC communities. Consolidating this bloc in the post-Nitish era will be critical to sustaining its momentum in the state, say BJP strategists. The party had got a scare in the run-up to the assembly election, when Shah had dropped hints that Nitish was not the natural choice for the top post. With doubts about Nitish's support base shifting to rival RJD, Shah was forced to backpedal and publicly state that the party was backing the JD(U) leader, that there was "no vacancy for the chief minister's post".

Where the BJP-led government may get traction early on is with the younger, aspirational, digitally-aware generation. Nearly 58 per cent of voters in Bihar are under 35, and the party would like to believe that its social media outreach, welfare targeting and cultural symbolism resonate deeply with this audience. The saffron party's hope now is that Nitish's shift to the Upper House in Parliament signals the emergence of a new political era in Bihar—one in which the dominance of Mandal-era stalwarts fades into the background. If it plays out according to script, as it has done so far, this may well be the BJP's defining moment in the state. ■